

BACK IN THE FOLD
Modi greets Bihar CM Nitish Kumar at an event in Aurangabad, Mar. 2

THE BJP, BY GETTING NITISH KUMAR TO REJOIN THE NDA IN BIHAR IN JANUARY NOT ONLY STRUCK A BODY BLOW TO THE I.N.D.I.A. GROUPING, BUT ALSO NEUTRALISED THE BACKWARD CLASS CHALLENGE IT POSED THAT HAD BECOME A THREAT TO ITS HINDUTVA CONSOLIDATION

wins, Modi effected a massive revamp of leadership, choosing relative newcomers to head the governments in the recently won states. A fourth of the candidates announced for the 400-odd seats are also fresh faces, especially in constituencies where the poor performance of sitting MPs has stoked anti-incumbency. To add weight to its campaign, the BJP has also inducted veterans to contest Lok Sabha seats. Among them are former chief ministers Shivraj Singh Chouhan in Madhya Pradesh, Manohar Lal Khattar in Haryana, Basavaraj Bommai in Karnataka, Trivendra Rawat in Uttarakhand and Biplab Deb in Tripura. "They all are our talent," says a top BJP leader. "The party has invested in them, they are needed at the Centre now to give freshness to Modi 3.0."

Even Union ministers who chose the Rajya Sabha route have been asked to contest. These include Jyotiraditya Scindia from Guna; Bhupender Yadav (Alwar, Rajasthan); Dharmendra Pradhan (Sambalpur, Odisha); Piyush Goyal (Mumbai North, Maharashtra); Mansukh Mandaviya (Porbandar, Gujarat); Sarbananda Sonowal (Dibrugarh, Assam); and Rajeev Chandrasekhar (Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala). Meanwhile, in Karnataka, the BJP is hoping for an encore of its previous performance—when it won 26 of the state's 28 LS seats—even if it lost the assembly election to the Congress in 2023. It is trying hard to win back the two dominant communities, the Vokkaligas and the Lingayats. It has tied up with Deve Gowda's Janata Dal-Secular (JDS) to attract Vokkaliga votes while anointing B.Y. Vijayendra, son of former CM B.S. Yediyurappa, as the state president to win back the Lingayat vote. Psephologist Yashwant Deshmukh, founder of CVoter, says what gives the BJP confidence overall is that of the 194 seats it was in a direct contest with the Congress in 2019, it won 185. Our latest MOTN poll shows the scenario hasn't changed much since, with the Congress still underperforming.

❷ MERGERS & ACQUISITIONS

The BJP's biggest challenge came when the Opposition parties combined forces, especially in the key swing states of Maharashtra that had 48 Lok Sabha seats and Bihar, which has 40. Of their 88 seats, the NDA had won 80 in 2019 and it is crucial that the party retains them in 2024. Towards that end, the BJP launched what psephologist Deshmukh calls 'Operation Mergers and Acquisitions'. In Maharashtra, the BJP had found itself isolated when ally Shiv Sena broke away from the NDA after the October 2019 assembly election and formed a new Opposition combine with the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) and the Congress, called the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA). Had the MVA contested in its full